

supported by the majority of the primary witnesses.¹ Even on this restricted basis the amount of variation recorded in the apparatus was dismaying. In this first chapter, each of the six witnesses differed from the ‘average’ Beta Text-type as follows: L, nineteen times (Westcott and Hort, twenty-one times); Aleph, twenty-six times; 2427, thirty-two times; 33, thirty-three times; B, thirty-four times; and 892, forty-one times. These results show convincingly that any attempt to reconstruct an archetype of the Beta Text-type on a quantitative basis is doomed to failure. The text thus reconstructed is not reconstructed but constructed; it is an artificial entity that never existed.² [A text-type with no archetype cannot represent the Original.]

Let us consider carefully what Colwell did, recalling that he was a partisan of the ‘Alexandrian’ text-type (his ‘Beta Text-type’). He attempted to arrive at the archetypal form of that text-type, for one chapter, by a majority vote of its known representatives, that he presumed to be the thirteen listed.³ The result was so impossibly bad that he discarded the seven ‘weaker’ representatives and tried again, using only the six ‘primary’ witnesses. In his own words: “Even on this restricted basis the amount of var-

¹ Note that his ‘mean’ text would not include a reading where the internal division was such that there was no majority; and since he only used six MSS, what did he do when they were evenly divided?

² Colwell, “The Significance of Grouping of New Testament Manuscripts”, *New Testament Studies*, IV (1957-1958), 86-87. Cf. also Colwell, “Genealogical Method”, pp. 119-123. Colwell follows Kenyon and uses “Beta text-type” to refer to today’s ‘Alexandrian’ text, whereas Hort used “b group” to refer to his ‘Western’ text.

³ Notice that the total representation of the text-type is just thirteen MSS (in the Gospels), and that number has not increased significantly since Colwell’s day (sixty years ago)—but recall that it has no demonstrable archetype. In contrast, the fifty-one f³⁵ MSS I have collated represent only some 20% of the extant family representatives, in the Gospels (around 250 MSS). It remains to be seen how many further families, within the Byzantine bulk, can be identified that have a single demonstrable archetypal form, based on a complete collation of all its representatives (or at least a sufficient proportion to establish the archetype). For the *TuT* volumes covering the first ten chapters of John, the *INTF* collated some 1875 MSS for 153 variant sets. Pages 54-90 in the first volume contain a list of ‘groupings’ of MSS; aside from their **K¹**, the largest group has 53 MSS, headed by MS 2103. The number of groups is bewildering. Further, with few exceptions, the groups or families identified by von Soden and others are limited to the Gospels; they do not exist throughout the 27 books that form our NT Canon. But if God inspired all 27 books, then He must have preserved all 27 books (or else why bother inspiring). Since the Autograph is the quintessential archetype, any candidate for that preservation should have an archetype, an empirically determined archetype, and for all 27 books—as of this writing, there is only one: Family 35.